

Stop Gerrymandering in Your County: A Toolkit for Fair Districts

A toolkit to build a nonpartisan grassroots network fighting for fair, transparent, community-led redistricting across the United States—one county at a time.



LADY LIBERTIE

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Ready to create the bones of a grassroots group for fair county maps? The kind of group anyone can start in their own backyard to fight gerrymandering locally and build pressure from the ground up. Here's everything you need to get started (after that, it requires your own grit, imagination and determination to save our democracy).

Mission

To ensure every voter in every county has equal representation by fighting for fair district maps drawn through transparent, inclusive, and community-driven processes.

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What To Do

As members of the Coalition you'll work at the **county and municipal levels** to:

- Investigate who draws local voting districts—and how
- Advocate for Independent Redistricting Commissions (IRCs) or open public processes
- Train and mobilize local residents to participate in hearings and submit public maps
- Monitor and report on redistricting activity by county boards and city councils
- Push for ballot initiatives or ordinances when officials won't act

Core Activities



Community Mapping Nights

Teach people how redistricting works and how to draw fair maps using tools like [Districtr.org](https://districtr.org).



Redistricting Watchdog Reports

Track who's drawing the maps, who's influencing them, and how the lines affect real people.



Candidate & Elected Official Pressure Campaigns

Get every local leader on the record: Do you support independent redistricting? Yes or no?



Ballot Measure Campaigns

When public officials refuse to act, we work with partners to put redistricting reform directly on the ballot.



Voter Education & Outreach

Host forums, make TikToks, knock doors—whatever it takes to make sure the public knows how gerrymandering works and why it matters.

How to Start Your Local Chapter

You don't need permission to start a local Fair Maps Coalition. You just need a few good people and a plan.

1. Gather 2–5 neighbors, friends, or fellow democracy nerds
2. **Claim your county:** e.g., Fair Maps [Your County]
3. Host your first meeting—online or in person
4. Investigate your local redistricting process
5. Reach out to existing groups for support (League of Women Voters, NAACP, etc.)
6. Start organizing!

Tools & Resources

What you get **right here** to start you off in the right direction:

- Starter kit with email templates, public comment guides, and map-drawing tools
- Sample ordinance language for creating a local IRC
- Coaching on ballot initiatives and coalition building
- A national signal boost for your wins and watchdog reports

Tagline Ideas

- *Democracy doesn't redraw itself.*
- *Every voter deserves a real voice.*
- *No more maps behind closed doors.*

Ready? Get set...Go!

The Fair County Maps Coalition Toolkit

A practical guide to organizing against gerrymandering in your county, city, or state.

About This Toolkit

This is your starter pack for fighting back against gerrymandering—whether you’re a seasoned organizer or just one ticked-off citizen tired of the lines being drawn behind closed doors. It includes templates, tools, and guidance to help you:

- Understand who draws the maps where you live
- Build public pressure for transparency and fairness
- Propose new ordinances for Independent Redistricting Commissions (IRCs)
- Mobilize your neighbors to get involved and stay loud

This toolkit is nonpartisan and designed for use in any U.S. county where fair elections are needed. Especially swing regions where maps are manipulated to mute voters.

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1. What Is Gerrymandering?

Gerrymandering is when political lines are drawn to give one group an unfair advantage. It weakens your vote by slicing up communities and rigging outcomes before the election even starts. The result? Elections where the winner was picked before a single vote was cast.

There are two main types:

- **Partisan Gerrymandering:** Manipulating districts to favor a political party.
- **Racial Gerrymandering:** Diluting the voting power of racial or ethnic communities.

Fair redistricting matters because it determines who represents you—and whether they have to listen.

1. Know Who Draws the Lines in Your Area

Use your Secretary of State's site or county election board to find:

- Who draws **local** maps (city council, school board, supervisors)?
- Who draws **state** maps (legislature, independent commission)?
- Is there a redistricting **advisory committee**? Who appoints it?
- Are meetings and decisions **open to the public**?

2. The Redistricting Checklist

- ☐ Look up the redistricting process in your city/county/state
- ☐ Find out when the next cycle begins (next big one is 2030)

- ☐ Identify who draws the maps—and who watches them
- ☐ Attend hearings and submit public comment
- ☐ Use [Districtr.org](https://districtr.org) to draft fair community maps
- ☐ Demand an Independent Redistricting Commission if one doesn't exist
- ☐ Push for transparency: open applications, public drafts, community review
- ☐ Build a coalition of neighbors, orgs, students, unions, and allies
- ☐ Run for office or support someone who will fight for fair maps
- ☐ Start a watchdog group to track redistricting votes and decisions

3. Sample Public Comment Guide

Use this structure when speaking at a hearing or submitting written comment:

- **Introduce Yourself:** Name, city, why you care
- **State Your Position Clearly:** “I support fair and transparent redistricting in our community.”
- **Name the Problem:** Call out gerrymandering, backroom decisions, or unfair representation
- **Propose a Solution:** Ask for an IRC, public input, or to reject a bad map
- **Share a Personal Story:** How has redistricting affected you or your neighborhood?
- **Close with a Demand:** “I ask this body to vote for fairness and reject partisan manipulation.”

4. Email Templates for Officials

Subject Line: Support Fair Redistricting in [Your County Name]

Dear [Official's Name],

I'm writing as a concerned resident of [City or County] to urge you to support fair, transparent, and community-led redistricting in our next cycle.

We deserve districts that reflect real communities—not political calculations.

Please:

1. Support the creation of an Independent Redistricting Commission
2. Ensure public hearings are accessible and well-publicized
3. Open applications for all redistricting advisory positions

I'm happy to speak further or connect you with residents who care deeply about this issue.

Sincerely,

[Your Name]

[Your City or ZIP]

5. Sample Ordinance Language for a Local IRC

Where it comes from: Model ordinances exist and can be adapted. These have been shared by:

- Nonpartisan voting rights groups like the Brennan Center for Justice and Common Cause
- City and county governments across the U.S. that have adopted independent redistricting commissions

"This ordinance establishes an Independent Redistricting Commission (IRC) to redraw the electoral district boundaries for [County/City Name] following each decennial U.S. Census. The Commission shall consist of [odd number, e.g., 9 or 13] members, selected through an open and transparent application process. Members must reflect the jurisdiction's diversity in terms of race, gender, geography, and political affiliation. No member shall have, within the previous five years, been a registered lobbyist, elected official, political party officer, or campaign contributor exceeding [set limit]. The Commission shall hold public hearings before and after draft maps are produced, accept and review maps submitted by residents, and draw boundaries based on the following criteria: equal population, compliance with the Voting Rights Act, contiguity, compactness, respect for communities of interest, and nonpartisan fairness."

Action: You can use this language as a starting point and adapt it to fit your local government structure. I recommend partnering with a local lawyer or advocacy organization to finalize the language and ensure legal compliance in your state.

6. Building a Fair Maps Coalition

Start with a few committed people and grow:

- Civic groups (League of Women Voters, NAACP, etc.)
- Student orgs & young voters
- Faith leaders
- Labor unions
- Local press and Substackers

Use shared values (fairness, accountability, representation) to unite across politics.

7. Community Mapping Events

Hold a community mapping night:

- Use tools like Districtr to draw maps together
- Educate people on what redistricting is and why it matters
- Gather stories of how district lines have impacted your area

- Submit your maps to local boards as public proposals

National Signal Boost: Spotlight Your Local Heroes

Through [The American Pamphleteer](#), I highlight local watchdogs and organizing wins:

- Submit your story, map, or campaign to be featured
- Get amplified through aligned Substacks and partner networks
- Celebrate success and grow momentum county by county

Action:

- Add a “Local Spotlight” section to your newsletter or blog—You could write a Substack too!
- Create a short submission form for organizers to share their work
- Partner with influencers (Like Lady Libertie), voting rights orgs, and democracy media to get the word out

10. Partner Organizations and Resources

- [Districtr.org](#) – Public mapping tool
- [Brennan Center for Justice](#) – Redistricting reform research & policy
- [League of Women Voters](#) – Local chapters and toolkits
- [Common Cause](#) – Organizing & legal support
- [Campaign Legal Center](#) – Advocacy & litigation help

11. Media & Messaging Tips

- Tell stories, not stats: Explain how unfair maps silence real people
- Use simple language: “This map splits my neighborhood and weakens our vote.”
- Stay nonpartisan and values-based: fairness, transparency, equal voice
- Repeat your demands clearly: open process, fair maps, community-led

12. Coaching on Ballot Initiatives & Coalition Building

Where it comes from: You can build a ballot initiative campaign using resources and training from:

- [Ballot Initiative Strategy Center](#)
- [Democracy Initiative](#)
- State chapters of ACLU or Common Cause (many offer redistricting support)

Action: Build a simple playbook:

- Step-by-step guide to launching a local or state initiative
- Timeline planning and signature gathering tips
- Coalition-building checklists
- Outreach scripts and organizing templates

Fair maps don't draw themselves.

They happen when ordinary people show up early, speak loudly, and stay organized. Use this toolkit, adapt it for your community, and start redrawing democracy—from the bottom up.

Ready? Go be loud. Be bold. Be *American*!

- *Lady Libertie*

Join the Resistance. Share this. Prepare Now.

Liked this? Subscribe to *The American Pamphleteer* on Substack. There are also books, resources and FREE pamphlets to pass out to your resistance group. <https://ladylibertie.substack.com/>
